

SPLENDOR AND seclusion

THE MUGHAL EMPIRE

The Mughal Empire (1526–1857) was synonymous with splendor, culture, power, and wealth. Its royal household held queens, mothers, and female elders in high regard, accommodating them in luxurious, female-only harems, or *zenanas*, along with concubines, servants, and slaves. Akbar I, the third Mughal emperor, reportedly had 5,000 women at his *zenana* in Fatehpur Sikri.

The *zenana* housed schools, playgrounds, bazaars, laundries, kitchens, and baths and was opulently decorated, furnished with verdant gardens, fountains, and pavilions. The lives of almost all its inhabitants revolved around the emperor—the greater a woman’s proximity to the emperor, the greater her benefits and privileges.

Hierarchy of the harem

The *zenana* was very hierarchical. The *Padshah Begum*, or the Chief Queen, was the most senior figure. However, as the Mughal Empire allowed polygamy there could be more than one Chief Queen. The highest-ranking female officials, the *Mahaldars*, controlled the *zenana* and would often spy for the emperor; below them were the *Paristan-é-hudur* (middle-ranking women); and lowest of all were the slaves who had entered the *zenana* as gifts or royal purchases.

The women were governed through strict rules of *purdah*—a Persian word meaning “curtain” that describes the practice of female seclusion—and were not free to wander outside the harem, which was guarded by *nazir*, or eunuchs. However, they were permitted to leave the *zenana* to accompany the emperor on hunting trips, excursions, or



◀ Opulent riches

Royal Mughal women were surrounded by treasures like this gem-encrusted box. One Mughal emperor was said to be wealthier than the emperors of France and Persia combined.

pilgrimages. Both the women of the *zenana* and the emperor himself were protected by *urdubegis*, women skilled in weapons and warfare.

Female education was confined to wealthy and royal families. Jahanara Begum, daughter of Shah Jahan and Mumtaz Mahal—for whom the Taj Mahal was built—headed the imperial harem from the age of 17, and patronized art and architecture. However, her brother, Emperor Aurangzeb, notably imprisoned his favorite daughter, Zeb-un-Nissa for daring to write poetry. She had been educated at court in mathematics, philosophy, and astronomy but her leanings toward poetry and music conflicted with her father’s orthodoxy, and she spent the last 20 years of her life locked away in Salimgarh Fort in Delhi.

From far lowlier beginnings, Begum Sumru was a dancer in the Mughal court who went on to rule the principality of Sardhana at the age of 25, and to contribute to the arts, as well as trade, finance, and religion. She is famed for defending Emperor Shah Alam II against Sikh invasion in 1783, when she rode into battle on a stallion, despite being only 4½ feet tall.

▶ Golden cage

Although they lived a life surrounded by luxuries, women in the *zenana* were governed through strict and restrictive rules of *purdah*. This miniature painting depicts a Mughal court *zenana*.